A Guide to Common Diseases

Simple information about causes, symptoms, prevention, and treatment approaches

Important: This guide is for education only. It cannot diagnose a person or replace advice from a qualified healthcare professional. Treatment depends on the individual and the condition.

1. What is a disease?

A disease is a condition that affects how the body or mind works. Causes may include infections, genetics, environmental exposures, lifestyle factors, or problems in organs or the immune system.

2. Infectious diseases

Common cold

Cause/spread: Usually caused by viruses; spreads through respiratory droplets and contaminated hands/surfaces.
Possible symptoms: Runny nose, sneezing, sore throat, cough, sometimes mild fever.
Care: Rest, fluids, and symptom relief. Antibiotics do not treat viral colds. Seek care for breathing difficulty or worsening symptoms.

Influenza (flu)

Cause/spread: A contagious influenza virus infection.
Possible symptoms: Fever/chills, muscle aches, headache, fatigue, cough, sore throat.
Care: Rest and fluids; antiviral medicines may be appropriate for some people. Urgent care for breathing difficulty, chest pain, confusion, or severe weakness.

COVID-19

Cause/spread: Caused by SARS-CoV-2 and spread mainly through the air.
Possible symptoms: Fever, cough, sore throat, fatigue, body aches, or breathing difficulty; symptoms vary.
Care: Follow local guidance and seek advice if at higher risk. Emergency care for severe breathing difficulty, chest pain, or confusion.

Tuberculosis (TB)

Cause/spread: Bacterial infection that often affects the lungs and spreads through the air.
Possible symptoms: Cough lasting weeks, fever, night sweats, weight loss, fatigue, or coughing blood.
Care: Needs testing and a complete prescribed course of medicines. Do not self-treat or stop treatment early.

Malaria

Cause/spread: A parasite transmitted by infected mosquitoes in affected areas.
Possible symptoms: Fever, chills, sweating, headache, body aches, fatigue.
Care: Prompt testing and clinician-prescribed antimalarial treatment are needed.

Dengue

Cause/spread: A virus spread by infected Aedes mosquitoes.
Possible symptoms: High fever, severe body aches, headache, pain behind the eyes, rash, nausea.
Care: Seek medical advice. Avoid aspirin/ibuprofen unless a clinician advises otherwise because bleeding risk can increase. Severe abdominal pain, persistent vomiting, bleeding, or unusual drowsiness needs urgent care.

Hepatitis B

Cause/spread: A virus affecting the liver; spread through infected blood and certain body fluids.
Possible symptoms: Often no symptoms; sometimes fatigue, nausea, abdominal discomfort, dark urine, yellow skin/eyes.
Care: Vaccination can prevent it. Testing and follow-up are important; some chronic cases need antiviral treatment.

HIV infection

Cause/spread: A virus that weakens the immune system and spreads through certain body fluids.
Possible symptoms: Early symptoms may resemble flu; later symptoms vary or may be absent for years.
Care: Testing is needed to know. Antiretroviral treatment can control HIV. Prevention includes condoms and appropriate preventive medicines.

3. Long-term and non-infectious diseases

Diabetes

What it is: Blood glucose stays too high because the body does not make enough insulin or cannot use it effectively.
Possible symptoms: Thirst, frequent urination, fatigue, blurred vision, or no early symptoms.
Care: Testing is needed. Care may include food/activity changes, glucose monitoring, and prescribed medicines or insulin.

High blood pressure

What it is: Blood pressure remains higher than recommended; often there are no symptoms.
Possible symptoms: Usually none. Very high pressure with chest pain, breathlessness, weakness, confusion, or vision changes is an emergency.
Care: Regular measurement, follow-up, lifestyle changes, and prescribed medicines may be needed.

Heart attack

What it is: Often occurs when blood flow to part of the heart muscle is blocked.
Possible symptoms: Chest pressure/pain, shortness of breath, sweating, nausea, or pain in arm, back, neck, or jaw.
Care: A suspected heart attack is an emergency. Call local emergency services immediately.

Stroke

What it is: Brain injury caused by blocked blood flow or bleeding in the brain.
Possible symptoms: Sudden face drooping, arm weakness, speech difficulty, vision problems, loss of balance, or severe unexplained headache.
Care: Emergency care immediately. Note when symptoms began; do not wait.

Asthma

What it is: Airways become inflamed and narrow; triggers can include allergens, smoke, exercise, or infections.
Possible symptoms: Wheezing, cough, chest tightness, shortness of breath.
Care: Use prescribed inhalers and follow an asthma plan. Severe breathing difficulty needs emergency care.

COPD

What it is: Long-term lung disease often associated with tobacco smoke or harmful airborne exposures.
Possible symptoms: Long-lasting cough, phlegm, breathlessness.
Care: Assessment, stopping smoking, vaccinations, inhalers, and pulmonary rehabilitation may help.

Chronic kidney disease

What it is: Gradual loss of kidney function, often associated with diabetes or high blood pressure.
Possible symptoms: Often no early symptoms; later swelling, fatigue, nausea, or urination changes.
Care: Blood and urine tests can detect it. Treatment focuses on the cause and protecting kidney function.

Cancer

What it is: A group of diseases in which abnormal cells grow uncontrollably; risks vary by cancer type.
Possible symptoms: A new lump, unexplained weight loss, unusual bleeding, persistent cough, or bowel/bladder changes may occur.
Care: Persistent or unusual symptoms should be assessed. Diagnosis and treatment depend on type and stage.

4. Other common health conditions

Migraine

A neurological condition causing recurring headache, sometimes with nausea or sensitivity to light/sound. Management may include trigger tracking and clinician-recommended medicines.

Arthritis

Joint inflammation or damage that may cause pain, stiffness, and reduced movement. Care depends on type and may include exercise, physiotherapy, medicines, and joint protection.

Anaemia

Low red blood cell count or haemoglobin. It may cause fatigue, weakness, dizziness, or breathlessness. Testing is needed to find the cause before treatment.

Depression

A mental health condition involving persistent low mood or loss of interest that affects daily life. Treatment can include therapy, support, and sometimes prescribed medication.

Obesity

A complex health condition involving excess body fat that can affect health. Support may include sustainable nutrition, activity, sleep, and clinician-guided treatment.

5. General prevention habits

- Keep vaccinations up to date according to local recommendations.
- Wash hands regularly, ventilate indoor spaces, and stay away from others when contagious.
- Eat a balanced diet, drink safe water, and be physically active within your ability.
- Avoid tobacco and vaping; limit or avoid alcohol.
- Sleep regularly and use healthy ways to manage stress.
- Use mosquito protection where mosquito-borne diseases occur.
- Have screening tests when recommended for your age and risk.
- Take medicines only as directed; do not share prescription medicines.

6. Emergency warning signs

Get emergency help for severe breathing difficulty; chest pain/pressure; signs of stroke (face droop, arm weakness, speech difficulty); sudden severe headache; loss of consciousness; seizure; severe bleeding; blue/grey lips; or a serious allergic reaction affecting breathing or the throat. In India, call 112 for emergency assistance where available.

7. Questions to ask about a disease

What causes it? How does it spread, if infectious? What symptoms can occur? How is it diagnosed? What treatments are available? How can it be prevented? Which warning signs need urgent care? Consult a qualified clinician for personal medical advice.

This guide covers selected common conditions, not every disease. Medical recommendations may change, and treatment must be tailored to the individual.